VS Code Professional Developer Extensions

Recommended setup for Full Stack Development (MERN), practical projects and professional coding workflows

1. Must-have extensions — install these first

Extension	Purpose
Prettier - Code formatter	Automatically formats code consistently across supported languages.
Error Lens	Shows errors and warnings directly beside the relevant code.
GitLens	Helps inspect Git history, commits, authorship and code changes.
Material Icon Theme	Adds clear file and folder icons to the Explorer.
Auto Rename Tag	Renames the matching HTML/XML tag when one tag is renamed.
Auto Close Tag	Automatically inserts closing HTML/XML tags.
Code Spell Checker	Catches spelling mistakes in identifiers, comments and text.
Live Server	Runs static HTML/CSS/JavaScript pages on a local development server.

2. Choose one theme (do not install all)

- Tokyo Night — Modern dark theme with clean blue/purple colours — recommended first choice.
- One Dark Pro — Popular professional dark theme with clear syntax colours.
- Dracula Official — Dark theme with distinctive, colourful syntax highlighting.
- Catppuccin for VSCode — Soft, modern and eye-friendly colour palette.
- Ayu — Minimal and professional-looking theme.
- GitHub Theme — Clean theme inspired by GitHub's interface.

3. Optional visual and productivity add-ons

- Peacock — Changes the VS Code window accent colour, useful with multiple projects.
- Indent Rainbow — Makes indentation levels easier to distinguish visually.
- CodeSnap — Creates clean screenshots of code.
- Todo Tree — Collects TODO, FIXME and similar comments in one place.
- vscode-icons — Alternative file and folder icon theme; optional if using Material Icon Theme.

4. MERN Stack / Full Stack development extensions

Extension	Purpose
ESLint	Finds JavaScript/TypeScript code-quality issues and applies configured rules.
ES7+ React/Redux/React-Native snippets	Provides shortcuts for common React code patterns.
Tailwind CSS IntelliSense	Autocomplete and editor support for Tailwind CSS classes.
Docker	Helps build, manage and inspect containers and images.
REST Client	Send HTTP requests from .http files inside VS Code.
MongoDB for VS Code	Connect to MongoDB and explore databases from the editor.

5. Recommended installation order

1. Install Prettier, Error Lens, GitLens and Material Icon Theme.

2. Choose one theme — start with Tokyo Night.

3. Add Auto Rename Tag, Auto Close Tag and Live Server for frontend work.

4. Add ESLint and React snippets when starting JavaScript/React projects.

5. Install Tailwind, Docker, REST Client and MongoDB extensions only when your project needs them.

Developer tip: Extensions improve your editor workflow, but they do not replace programming fundamentals. Prioritise JavaScript, React, Node.js, APIs, databases, Git, debugging, data structures and algorithms, and system design. Install only trusted extensions and review their publisher and permissions.